Uriah Raffer

Statement of Qualifications

JC-521544, Lead Service Desk Technician

1. Describe in detail your experience working at an IT Service Desk and providing excellent customer service. Explain how your knowledge, skills, and education would make you a desirable candidate for this position, including your experience in establishing, maintaining, and enforcing IT Service Desk standards, processes, and procedures.

My hands-on Information Technology (IT) support experience comes from two places. The first is a tiered troubleshooting lab I completed for my Bachelor of Science in Network Engineering and Security at Western Governors University. The second is my current cybersecurity internship at Log(N) Pacific. The lab put me in a working support role across Tier 1 through Tier 3, diagnosing real faults to root cause and confirming normal operation before closing each ticket. At Tier 1 that meant the fast first-line work a service desk sees every day, like restoring a workstation that had lost connectivity because someone had set a manual static Internet Protocol (IP) address instead of letting it pull one automatically, and clearing account lockouts so users could get back to work. Higher tiers took deeper desktop, operating system, and network troubleshooting. I am comfortable owning a problem from first user contact through to a verified fix.

Beyond the lab, I keep these skills current in a homelab I run myself. There I work directly with hardware and system images, building and deploying operating system images and creating and troubleshooting virtual machines on a Proxmox Virtual Environment host to keep the environment running. I also use remote-access tools every day, running Tailscale and RustDesk together to reach and support my own machines across different networks. That is the same kind of remote troubleshooting this position calls for when it supports district offices and remote sites, where the technician is often not sitting at the machine that has the problem. Configuring, deploying, and supporting workstations, software, operating systems, and peripherals is work I do hands-on and enjoy.

Excellent customer service is the part of this work I am most confident in, and I built it before I worked in technology. As a tax preparer at Block Advisors I sat across from people who were anxious about their returns and did not know tax law. My job was to keep them calm, explain plainly what was happening and what it meant for them, and get them to an accurate result without talking over their heads. The same instinct carries into support. I listen first, I stay factual when someone is frustrated, and I keep the focus on the outcome rather than on being right. When a customer and I are not connecting, I would rather hand the ticket to a teammate or escalate than let the person wait.

On the standards and process side, my experience is in maintaining and following procedures and in building repeatable ones. On my internship I document every issue and its fix in plain, repeatable write-ups so another technician can follow exactly what I did, the same purpose a knowledge base article serves. I follow established procedures rather than improvising. The internship also taught me to prioritize by impact when the work stacks up. Authenticated vulnerability scans surfaced more findings than I could fix at once, so I triaged them by severity and exposure, remediated the highest-risk software and misconfigurations first with PowerShell, and scheduled recurring scans so the work stayed current instead of being done once and forgotten. That brought identified vulnerabilities down by roughly 90% across scan cycles. A

ticket queue runs on the same judgment, where impact and urgency decide what gets worked first, and I hold to standards because I understand why they exist.

I also understand that a lead adds more than ticket fixes, and I bring the habits that role rewards. I document my work so others can pick it up, which is the same muscle as helping bring along the Associate Service Desk Specialists and Student Assistants this role mentors, and I step up when the team is short. At Robert's Retirement I normally processed life insurance applications, and when the coworker who handled annuity processing was out for a week I covered her workload on top of my own. Much of it was new to me, so I coordinated directly with the partner team at Athene who supported that work, kept both sets of tasks moving, and closed the week with no complaints. Keeping service running when someone is out, and helping the people around me do the same, is the part of a lead role I am ready for.

2. Describe a time when you had to troubleshoot a complex technical problem that required innovative thinking and collaboration with other team members. Detail the steps you took to diagnose and resolve the issue, and explain how your approach to problem-solving enhances your ability to work in an IT Service Desk environment.

One of the more involved problems I worked in my Western Governors University lab started as a single complaint. A user's regular work site kept loading the wrong page. The obvious read was a problem with that one machine, but I did not assume it. I tried the site from my own computer and asked several other users to do the same. It failed for all of us, and that result was the key to the whole diagnosis. Because everyone could reproduce it, the fault had to live in shared infrastructure, not on one endpoint. That also ruled out the kind of attack that targets a single machine, like an edited hosts file, which would have hit only that one user and would never have shown up in a shared system. The reproduction step was not just confirming something was wrong, it told me where to look.

With the problem localized to the network rather than the desktop, I opened the Windows Domain Name System (DNS) Manager and found a rogue forward lookup zone that was redirecting the domain to the wrong destination. I deleted the zone, had the user flush their DNS cache, and the site resolved correctly. I kept the change targeted to the actual fault instead of reworking the wider configuration.

That experience is how I approach a service desk. I treat the first report as a starting point, not the full picture, and I bring other people in early. Asking others to reproduce an issue is often the fastest way to tell a one-person problem from a system-wide one, and on a busy desk that same instinct means looping in the right Tier 2 group or vendor rather than sitting on a ticket I cannot close alone. I reason about what the evidence rules in and rules out before I touch anything, which keeps me from chasing the wrong fix while users wait.